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California expands historic commitment to local journalism fellowships

August 2, 2025 | Lake County News (CA)
Author: LAKE COUNTY NEWS REPORTS | Section: News | 663 Words
OpenURL Link

California is expanding its historic commitment to local journalism with a $15 million budget allocation for fellowships to early-career reporters and editors and training to strengthen the economic viability of news outlets.

This commitment will fund another infusion of California Local News Fellows — the nation's largest publicly funded journalism initiative based at UC Berkeley Journalism — and will expand the program to include editing fellows.

Lingzi Chen, staff reporter for Lake County News, is a California Local News Fellow and part of the program's second cohort. She joined the publication in September 2024.

Leadership and sustainability training and support for California newsrooms will be provided by the Maynard Institute's Propel Initiative, in collaboration with California Black Media, the Latino Media Collaborative and American Community Media.

"California is stepping up once again to support local journalism at a time when our democracy and the cohesion of our communities depend on fact-based reporting," said Elena Conis, interim dean of UC Berkeley Journalism. "The state's historic commitment signals that journalism is a precious public resource that contributes to the health and well-being of our state."

"This funding strengthens the people and organizations anchoring local journalism in communities across California," said Martin G. Reynolds, co-executive director of the Robert C. Maynard Institute for Journalism Education. "It recognizes that the work these outlets and journalists do every day is essential to a democratic and informed society. By investing in those closest to the story, California is building a future where local news is not only sustainable, but truly reflective of the people it serves. The Institute is proud to work alongside Berkeley Journalism and our Propel partners in this historic, community-led coalition — a model for how states can support journalism that serves all of their residents."

The FY26 budget will support California Local News Fellowships — in reporting and editing — to begin in 2026 and continue through 2028. The Maynard Institute's Propel Initiative will equip journalists and publishers with practical tools for leadership and business sustainability, helping local outlets build long-term strength and resilience.

"Even in tight financial times, independent journalism, which underpins a citizen-informed democracy, is deserving of priority support," said former State Senator Steve Glazer — who spearheaded a $25 million allocation in 2023 to launch the California Local News Fellowship Program. "I appreciate the legislative leadership by Senator Catherine Blakespear (D-Encinitas) and Assemblymember Marc Berman (D-Menlo Park) for championing this program's renewal and expansion. They were supported by budget leaders Senators Scott Wiener (D-San Francisco) and John Laird (D-Santa Cruz) and Assemblymembers Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) and David Alvarez (D-San Diego)." Glazer championed this latest effort as a volunteer.

The California Local News Fellowship program currently supports more than 70 full-time reporters (with full-time pay and benefits), who report approximately 100 stories per week.

Fellows such as Chen cover critical stories on immigration, climate change, and federal policies that affect Californians, especially in largely underserved communities.

They are based in newsrooms across the state, in counties that account for approximately 92 percent of California's population.

A third cohort of full-time reporting fellows, supported by the state's initial investment, will start working in newsrooms this fall.

The Propel Initiative is a statewide training and leadership program that supports the people who power California's local newsrooms. The initiative prioritizes support for ethnic media and community-based outlets, while also serving journalists and publishers across the journalism sector.

Through coaching, business sustainability training, editorial leadership development, and peer learning, Propel equips participants with the tools and support needed to build a more resilient and representative local news ecosystem.

"This approved fund is significant in terms of the state recognizing and supporting the crucial role of local news media in helping promote and preserve democracy in these trying times," said Sandy Close, executive director of American Community Media.

"How we got here is historic," said Julian Do, American Community Media's co-director, "as all media sectors and groups — from mainstream and multicultural news outlets to journalism schools, unions, and media groups — have come together with one goal: to serve the public."

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  COUNTY NEWS REPORTS, L. (2025, August 2). California expands historic commitment to local journalism fellowships*Lake County News (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A23D71EB59BCCF8.